

Moonsea Rising - 20240519

Building the Playset

Dieral tells them the card, The Talon, had given him visions of the devil coming to kill him. He offers it to them, along with a couple of salamander elixirs he has made. He is afraid the devil will return for the card. He is devout fan of the War for the Crown, and shows them a tattoo of "The Druid". Highly-stylized, a little pin-uppy, it shows an elf in a low-cut green dress, with an eye patch, and a dinosaur in the background. Lirael's good eye narrows slightly, but she doesn't say anything.

Taevyn asks Dieral if he knows anyone else with the rare variants. He only knows of the two shops to which they've been. He takes Lirael's advice to not be found by the devil, thinking maybe he'll relocate to Phlan.

Discussing where to get off the streets, they recall passing the sign for the Cock and Bull on their way to the bazaar. Several of the party members remember it from their last visit to the city, and they make their way there. The proprietor, Garth, has rooms for long-term let, and is more than willing to rent. The bar is full of many races drinking and having fun. Though Melvaunt is more racially-diverse than it used to be, elves seem to be quite rare. The party elects to get some rooms, and beds down for the night.

Sun and Storm

They all share a vivid dream in which they are together at the doors to a large structure, which dream-Beitris identifies as the Opera House in her original Melvaunt, which had become the House of Sun and Storm. It stands alone, rather than in its traditional context. The doors swing open, and they all feel compelled to enter. Inside, they find the temple as it was, full of priests and penitents, engaged in normal worship.

At the alter, a high priest unfamiliar to Beitris is preaching, and she doesn't recognize the other priests or the flock. Looking around, Beitris moves to sit in the pews up front. Lirael prods the pews with her toe, wondering at the reality of everything, but it all seems solid. Beitris listens attentively as the High Priest praises Edric, talking of his sacrifices, and postulating the awfulness that might have been if he had not done what he did. Trade, seafrosts, orcish raids; all of these things are no longer, thanks to Edric. And for all these good works, Edric was beatified to sit at the right hand of Lathander.

As the service ends, the party turns at a loud, sarcastic, slow clap coming from the back of the temple. There, the devil smirks, deriding the sermon's content, though none other than the party seem to hear him. Taevyn leaps up, drawing his rapier, and telling everyone to take cover while they take care of it. The devil laughs, telling them he will soon take their cards from them, for his master. He leaves, telling them he will see them soon in the waking world.

Harken notes that he refers to the dream of the temple as "holy ground." He thinks that consecrated ground might weaken the devil, while Lireal thinks extended imprisonment might well kill it. The high priest moves through the parishioners, greeting them. When he sees Beitris, he clasps her hands and tells her "reclaimed paradise" will be her's. Taevyn asks her about that, and she tells him the Church in her time was quite corrupt, but "reclaimed paradise" isn't any doctrine of which she's aware.

Lirael is studying the parishioners' attire and tells them to look at it. It seems more like the time in which they began than the time in which they find themselves. She also says she thought the devil looked surprised to see them, so wonders why they are in this dream. She examines The Talon, finding its aura divine. She wonders if it is the reason they were brought to where the devil was.

Exiting the temple, they no find themselves on a short representation of the street of Melvaunt. At one end of the street is an older temple to Selûne; at the other is a pallisade which appears to be the entrance to the temple of Xul'jarak.

Return to Xul'jarak

Beitris recalls that Jessica Talianos, captain of the Silverswords, was a priestess of Selûne. She passes this information along, but suggests they explore Xul'jarak. There are no guards, and they make their way to the main room. The chest and the floating entity are present, and as Lireal makes her way to the chest. In her mind, she can feel the General's excitement. As she pulls out the card to compare, the entity speaks. "You have done so much, but you can do more. What will you choose?"

She reaches out to the General in her mind, and he exults in what they've already done. She asks him what more they can do, but he doesn't which to say. The entity, likewise, tells her she can do anything she likes. Harken suggests they collect all the cards and make reality whatever they like. She's still a little uncomfortable with that, but does want to ensure peace among the intelligent races. Taevyn wants the devils stopped, and Lireal asks what their goal is. The entity tells her that the devils clearly want the cards to make choices, or to prevent others from making choices. He names the devil, Vharnev the Butcher, at which Beitris' ears perk up.

While the entity speaks of choices, he offers none. Beitris, impatient to see what the Goddess of the Moon has to offer them, moves to leave for the Temple of Selûne. The others follow, with Taevyn waiting on Lireal before he leaves. He tells her perhaps the cards can make her fully elven again. She smiles, and says that her sacrifice was necessary and she doesn't regret it. He mentions that she was prettier before her transformation, for which she thanks him.

The Moon

Heading towards the Temple of the Moon, they find a fourth structure on their dream street -- the Laronium. Entering the temple, they instead find themselves in a warehouse with racks and racks of silvered arms and armor. Paladins and their squires bustle about getting outfitted. A large table under a chandelier has Jessica and others planning an attack against the Zhentarim. She greets them as though she'd been expecting them, and turns back to planning an attack on Zhentil Keep.

She has tokens representing the Zhent forces, including a red figure with a giant axe, and a man with stag horns. Beitris immediately engages Jessica, speaking about the battle plans, and asking about Vharnev and the druid. Jessica says they know little about the druid, and asks Beitris what she knows, but she knows even less. Jessica says Edric is going to use the chest to breach the walls of the Keep so the Silverswords can exterminate the Zhentarim. As Harken and Beitris theorcraft about what Vharnev might want, she notices that the planning doesn't seem to be progressing. The scene they're in seems to be fairly static, as though it were a simple slice of time. Beitris is getting bored, as she wonders what they're supposed to see in this dream, and Lirael wonders why the card, she assumes, has brought them here.

The Wizard's House

They check out the Laronium, finding an arcane library par excellence. A rather pompous librarian directs them to a tome on reality-bending artifacts which seems rather pointed about not using powerful artifacts without centuries of study. Beitris finds a spellbook with two spells she can read: outcasts' curse and crushing despair. Deciding that the group is under attack by dream magic, Beitris forces herself to wake up, disappearing from the Laronium. Keeping her eyes closed, she tries to sense any unexpected presences in the room, but detects nothing. Grabbing a weapon, she quickly searches the suite. Finding a copy of the game they grabbed on a table, the board is out and set up. It is places of import in the game, and it looks poorly-made, other than four locations in the game which appear in vibrant, bright color. Unsurprisingly, it's the Laronium, The Temples of Sun and Storm, Selûne, and Xul'jarak.

She wakes the others, explaining what she found. Lirael says she doesn't think anyone has set up the game, but rather the magicks are interacting with one another. Examining the board game rules, they find the cards are affiliated with gaining access to a benefit on a region of the board game. It is about the founding of the Empire, and the highest possible score is achieved by doing what was done in their timeline. The Dagger card allows the player to declare their move last, with knowledge of all other moves.

The cards as well allow access to a metaphysical representation of places that provide them with additional powers. Beitris mentions that The Dagger is still pointing towards the market, and Lirael wants to spend more time studying the rules, to see what the other cards might portend or where they might be found.